> It is a fear that comes of the knowledge that normalcy is utterly contingent, that the spaces that surround one, the streets that one inhabits, can become, suddenly and without warning, as hostile as a desert in a flash flood. It is this that sets apart the thousand million people who inhabit the subcontinent from the rest of the world—not language, not food, not music—it is the special quality of loneliness that grows out of the fear of the war between oneself and one's image in the mirror.

This fear had set in many months before Partition and refugee camps had already been set up due to violent communal riots in some places. The wealthy elites, money lenders and landlords were the first to depart, by motor and air transport to the other sides, whereas the relatively poor were huddled into refugee camps waiting for clarity over the exact boundary.[19] After the notification of the boundary, between August and October 1947, the displacement was spontaneous, violent and exhausting. The transportation routes were chock-a-bloc with people and carts. Week-long journeys were much shorter than those endured by Indians fleeing Burma in 1942 but were more complicated as it was a crisis with two-way traffic. The rural masses dominated the foot columns while the urban folk dominated the refugee trains known as 'India Specials' and 'Pakistan Specials', carrying 2000 or more passengers each, without ticket charges. While trains were a faster way to get across the border, they were also potential death traps.

The scale of the crisis finally dawned after two million people had already moved to each side, and in mid-October 1947, the Military Evacuee Organization (MEO) of India and Pakistan formulated a Joint Evacuation Movement. The detailed plan covered strategies on evacuation, relief and transport to move people from transit camps to refugee camps across the border. Thousands of military and civilian trucks were pressed into service. Schedules were drawn to avoid clashes of caravans moving in opposite directions. Government employees were given preference during evacuation and many were airlifted out of crisis zones with flights between Lahore, Quetta, Rawalpindi, Peshawar, Karachi, Bombay and Delhi. The MEO was updated by the District Liaison Officers about 'stranded refugees, abduction of women and children and forcible conversions taking place in